The First Week: Remote Team Lead Simulation

Storyboard, Branching Map and Design Rationale

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Case study at a glance: PROBLEM: new remote team leads carry in office habits that block work across time zones. MY ROLE: sole instructional designer (learner profile, scenario writing, branching logic, evaluation plan). TOOLS: Articulate Storyline 360 for the build, with a Rise 360 style reference panel. STATUS: storyboard and branching map complete; build is the next step. OUTCOME: a five decision simulation with three live meters and a pattern based debrief instead of a score.

1. Design Overview

Topic: Remote Team Collaboration and Async Communication

Format: Short branching scenario simulation (about 10 to 12 minutes, five decisions). It is a scenario, not a microlearning module in the strict sense (one objective, 3 to 5 minutes); the true microlearning series is in Part 2. The simulation has no quiz, no flashcards and no linear content then test flow

Design principle: PRACTICE FIRST, CONTENT ON DEMAND. The learner acts, sees consequences, and only then pulls in reference material if they want it.

Why this differs from Projects 1 to 4: The four earlier modules share one pattern (setup, flashcards, drag and drop, quiz, scenario, checklist, assessment). This project replaces that pattern with a decision loop, live variables and a pattern based debrief. It is designed to show range, not repeat a template.

Companion piece: Part 2 is a five part microlearning series and a job aid that extend the skills practised here (see the separate curriculum document).

2. The Problem and the Learner

Business problem: Newly promoted or newly hired team leads manage people across time zones but carry in office habits: vague messages, unplanned calls, silent assumptions. The result is blocked work, missed deadlines and low trust.

Evidence the problem is real: Buffer's 2021 State of Remote Work report found that 16 percent of remote workers named collaboration and communication as their biggest struggle. Among people who became remote workers after the pandemic it was 20.5

percent, against 13 percent for longer term remote workers. Buffer's 2020 report says collaboration and communication difficulties stayed in the top three struggles across three years of survey data. The gap is largest for people new to remote work, which matches this learner. These are surveys of remote workers in general, not data on team leads.

Target learner: First time or early career team leads (0 to 2 years of leading others) on distributed teams of 4 to 12 people in 2 or 3 time zones.

What they already know: How to do their own job well, and basic email and chat tools.

What they lack: A repeatable way to communicate and decide when they cannot walk over to someone's desk.

Constraints: Short attention windows, mobile access likely, no appetite for long courses.

3. Learning Outcomes

By the end of the simulation, the learner will be able to:

1. **CLARIFY** an ambiguous status update by asking specific, answerable questions (what is done, what is left, what is blocking, when).
2. **DESIGN** a handoff across time zones so that work is not blocked overnight.
3. **DEESCALATE** a public disagreement by moving it to the right channel and closing the loop in writing.
4. **REPORT** upward using a structured async update (status, risks, asks).

Each outcome maps to exactly one decision day (see the alignment table in Section 8).

4. Simulation Mechanics

Role: You are Alex, a new team lead. The team: Priya (Dubai), Marcus (Toronto), Sam (Lisbon), and Dana, your director (Toronto).

Structure: Five simulated days (Monday to Friday). One key decision per day, three options each.

Visible variables (shown as three meters, updated after every decision):

Variable	Start	Meaning	Good direction
TEAM TRUST	5 / 10	How safe and respected the team feels	Higher
DEADLINE RISK	4 / 10	Likelihood the Friday deliverable slips	Lower
TEAM ENERGY	6 / 10	Workload and morale	Higher

Reference Library (on demand): A side panel with four items: Async Message Checklist, Handoff Note Template, Escalation Ladder, and BLUF Update Template. Opening an item costs nothing, but the simulation logs WHICH items the learner opened and WHEN (before or after deciding). This feeds the debrief.

Feedback style: No "correct/incorrect" banners. Learners see a short consequence scene (a reply, a chat thread, a silence) and the meters moving. Explanations appear only in the debrief.

5. Scene by Scene Storyboard

Day 1, Monday: The Kickoff (Outcome: foundation, sets the tone)

Scene: Your first team message. Priya will be online for 3 more hours, Marcus has just started his day, and Sam is midafternoon. The Friday deliverable is a client report.

Decision: How do you open the week?

- **A. Schedule a live kickoff call in 20 minutes.** Consequence: Priya joins late, Sam is already deep in other work and misses it. Trust -1, Deadline Risk +1, Energy -1.
- **B. Post a written kickoff:** goals, owners, deadlines, and a 5 minute recorded walkthrough for questions. Consequence: Replies trickle in over the day with specific questions. Trust +2, Deadline Risk -1, Energy 0.
- **C. Post a short "Welcome everyone, let's have a great week!" message.** Consequence: Three emoji reactions, zero clarity. Trust 0, Deadline Risk +1, Energy 0.

Day 2, Tuesday: The Vague Update (Outcome 1: CLARIFY)

Scene: Sam posts: "Done, mostly." Nothing else.

Decision: How do you respond?

- **A. Reply "Ok great, thanks!"** Consequence: Hidden problem surfaces later (see Day 3 variant). Trust 0, Deadline Risk +2.

- **B. Reply in thread with four specific questions:** what is finished, what remains, any blockers, expected completion. Consequence: Sam answers in full within the hour and flags a dependency on Marcus. Trust +1, Deadline Risk -2.
- **C. Ask Sam to jump on a call right now.** Consequence: Works, but pulls Sam out of focus time and sets a call first habit. Trust 0, Deadline Risk -1, Energy -1.

Day 3, Wednesday: The Overnight Block (Outcome 2: DESIGN handoffs)

Scene: Priya is blocked, waiting for Marcus's approval. It is the middle of Marcus's night. If this stays unsolved, Thursday is lost.

Decision: What do you do?

- **A. Ping Marcus directly at his 2 a.m.** Consequence: Marcus replies groggily, annoyed. Trust -2, Deadline Risk -1, Energy -1.
- **B. Write a handoff note and set a standing approval window** (Marcus approves by 9 a.m. his time; Priya gets a clear fallback if he cannot). Consequence: Priya continues with a preapproved fallback, Marcus approves at 8:40 a.m. Trust +2, Deadline Risk -2, Energy +1.
- **C. Do Priya's task yourself to keep things moving.** Consequence: It ships, but you are exhausted and the process problem remains. Trust -1, Deadline Risk -1, Energy -2.

Branch note: If the learner chose Day 2 option A, a bonus problem appears here: Sam's "mostly done" work was missing a key section, so Deadline Risk rises by an extra 2 before this decision is made.

Day 4, Thursday: The Chat Flare Up (Outcome 3: DEESCALATE)

Scene: In the team channel, Marcus and Priya exchange sharp messages about the blocked approval. Others are silent.

Decision: How do you respond?

- **A. Reply publicly, pointing out who was at fault.** Consequence: Silence, then Sam sends you a private message about feeling unsafe to post. Trust -3, Energy -2.
- **B. Speak to each person privately, then post a short written resolution and a new rule for approvals.** Consequence: Both thank you; the channel returns to normal. Trust +2, Energy +1.
- **C. Stay out of it and hope it fades.** Consequence: It fades, but Priya starts withholding updates. Trust -1, Deadline Risk +1.

Branch note: If Trust is 3 or below at the start of Day 4, the conflict escalates and an extra option appears: **D. Call an urgent all hands.** It partially repairs the situation (Trust +1, Energy -2) but is not rated as the best choice.

Day 5, Friday: The Upward Update (Outcome 4: REPORT)

Scene: Dana asks for a status update before her weekend begins in Toronto.

Decision: How do you write it?

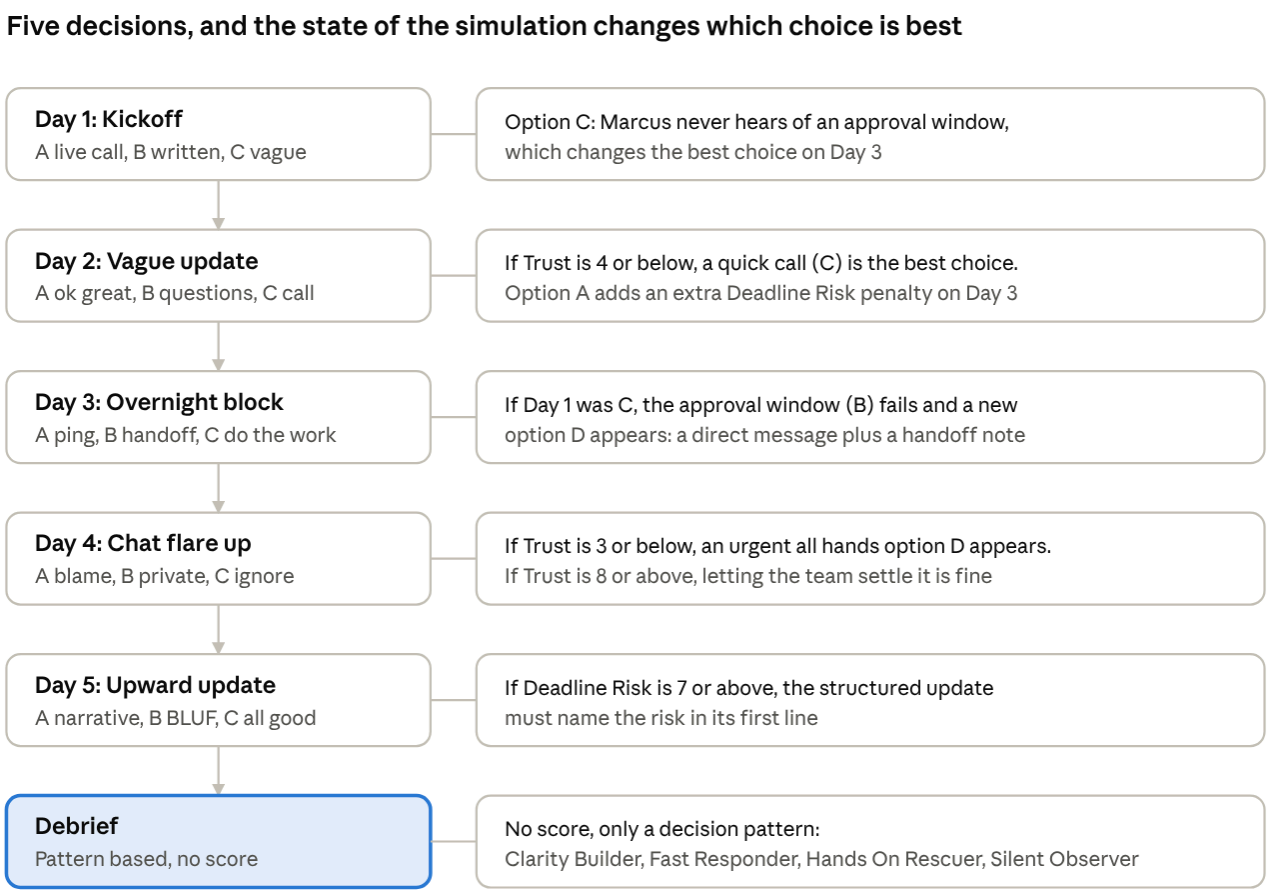
- **A. A long narrative of everything that happened this week.** Consequence: Dana replies, "Can you summarise?" Trust -1, Deadline Risk 0.
- **B. A structured BLUF update:** Status (one line), Risks (two bullets), Asks (one decision needed from Dana). Consequence: Dana replies with a one word approval and the decision. Trust +1, Deadline Risk -1.
- **C. "All good, nothing to flag."** Consequence: Dana is surprised on Monday by the issues you did not mention. Trust -2, Deadline Risk +2.

5A. Context Rules: No Single Best Letter

In the first draft, option B was the best choice every day. That is predictable and learners can game it. These rules make the best choice depend on the state of the simulation, and the option order is shuffled at build time.

- **Day 2:** If Trust is 4 or below, option C (a quick call) becomes the strongest choice: Trust +2, Deadline Risk -2. Written questions alone read as cold when trust is already low (option B then gives Trust 0).
- **Day 3:** If Day 1 was option C, Marcus never heard about an approval window, so option B fails (Trust -1, Deadline Risk 0). The best move becomes a new option D: a polite direct message to Marcus plus a handoff note (Trust +1, Deadline Risk -2).
- **Day 4:** If Trust is 8 or above, option C (let the team settle it) is acceptable: Trust +1, Energy 0, because the team shows it can correct itself. Option B still works but costs Energy -1 by adding process the team does not need.
- **Day 5:** If Deadline Risk is 7 or above, a structured update is still best, but only if its first line names the risk. Option B without a risk line scores Trust -1 and Deadline Risk +1.
- **Feedback rule:** The debrief never says correct or incorrect. It shows what each choice cost or bought in that context.

6. Branching Map (Decision Tree)



branching map · 5 decisions, context rules, 1 debrief

Each day has three options. The notes on the right show where the state of the simulation changes which option is best or adds a new one.

Possible endings (based on final meters):

- **Strong Week:** Trust 8 or above and Deadline Risk 3 or below.
- **Recoverable Week:** Mixed meters; the team delivers but with strain.
- **Fragile Week:** Trust 4 or below or Deadline Risk 7 or above; the debrief focuses on repair strategy.

7. Debrief Design

There is no percentage score. The debrief shows the learner's DECISION PATTERN across the five days:

- **Clarity Builder:** Chose structured, specific, written options (mostly B).
- **Fast Responder:** Favoured speed and live calls (mostly C or A on Days 1 and 2).

- **Hands On Rescuer:** Absorbed problems personally instead of fixing the process (Day 3 C).
- **Silent Observer:** Avoided or undercommunicated (Day 4 C, Day 5 C).

Each pattern includes: a plain language description, one strength, one blind spot, and one next action linked to the Reference Library item that would help most.

Reflection prompt (open response, not graded): "Which day felt hardest to decide, and what would you do differently in your real team this week?"

8. Alignment Table (Outcome, Activity, Evidence)

Outcome	Activity	Evidence of learning
1. CLARIFY	Day 2 decision	Option B chosen; Reference Library item opened before or after
2. DESIGN handoffs	Day 3 decision	Option B chosen; Deadline Risk reduced
3. DEESCALATE	Day 4 decision	Option B chosen; Trust recovered
4. REPORT	Day 5 decision	Option B chosen; Dana's response
Overall	Debrief and reflection	Pattern identified; written commitment to one change

9. Build Notes (Storyline 360 or Rise 360)

- Use Storyline variables for the three meters (Trust, Risk, Energy) and a trigger on each choice layer to update them.
- One slide per day, with chat style consequence layers; no scoring slide.
- Reference Library as a persistent slide master panel; use a variable to log which items were opened.
- Debrief slide uses conditional branching on a counter variable per option type.
- Accessibility: all meters need text equivalents; avoid colour only signalling; provide transcripts for the recorded walkthrough.

10. Design Decisions to Mention in the Portfolio Case Study

1. **Why simulation:** The skill being taught is judgment under ambiguity, which a quiz cannot assess.

2. **Why no pass/fail:** Real work rarely gives a clean score; pattern feedback is more useful.
3. **Why content on demand:** It respects experienced adult learners and gives me behavioural data on when they seek help.
4. **What I would test with real learners:** Whether the three option structure feels too obvious, and whether the extra branches on Days 3 and 4 are noticeable enough.

11. Evaluation Plan (Proposed)

Purpose: show whether the simulation changes how new team leads write and decide across time zones, not only whether they liked it. The plan is built for a pilot with 6 to 8 first time team leads and a manager for each. It uses the four Kirkpatrick levels, with a baseline taken before the simulation so every result has something to be compared with.

Level	Question	Instrument	Success criterion (proposed)	When
1 Reaction	Was it relevant and realistic, and do learners feel more confident?	Three item survey, 5 point scale: relevance, realism, confidence	Average of 4 or higher on all three items	Right after the debrief
2 Learning	Do learners make better decisions in a new scenario?	Pre test and post test: a fresh vague update scenario, scored on how many of four clarifying questions are asked (what is done, what is left, any blocker, expected date)	Post test average at least 1 point higher than the pre test	Pre test before, post test within one week
3 Behaviour	Do real updates improve?	Manager scores three real team updates before and three after, using the BLUF rubric below	Average rubric score up by at least 2 points out of 8	Baseline before, follow up after 30 days
4 Results	Does work flow better?	Blocked tasks per week and missed handoffs, counted by the team	Fewer blocked tasks than the baseline month (indicative only)	After 60 days

BLUF update rubric (0 to 2 points for each criterion, 8 maximum): the status is stated in the first line; risks are named and each has an owner; the ask or decision needed is explicit; the update can be understood without a follow up question.

How results change the design: If Level 2 improves but Level 3 does not, the skill is learned but not used at work, so the job aid and spaced practice in Part 2 become the priority. If Level 1 is low, the scenarios need to be made more realistic before anything else changes.

Limits: The success criteria are proposed targets set by the designer, not benchmarks. Level 4 cannot prove cause, because other changes also affect team results. No pilot results are reported in this document.

12. Assumptions and Reference Frameworks

This is a self initiated portfolio project, not a client brief. The evidence comes from public worker surveys and published practice, not from interviews or company data, so the learner profile stays an assumption to validate with real learners and a manager before any real build. All sources below were accessed on 27 October 2026.

- **Handoffs and async norms (Day 2, Day 3, Day 4):** GitLab Handbook, Asynchronous communication for remote work. Basis for the handoff design (document everything, then transfer ownership to the next person) and for the rule that a live call is justified when a matter is urgent or async has stopped working.
- **Written updates (Day 5):** BLUF (communication) traces the convention to US Army Regulation 25-50. Bite Size Learning, BLUF gives the practical rule and warns that some cultures find a direct opening too blunt with senior people, a limit worth noting in the debrief.
- **Evidence of the problem:** Buffer, State of Remote Work 2021 and 2020.
- **Evaluation plan:** Training Industry, The Kirkpatrick Model.
- **Learning outcomes:** Anderson, L. W., & Krathwohl, D. R. (2001). A Taxonomy for Learning, Teaching, and Assessing: A Revision of Bloom's Taxonomy of Educational Objectives.